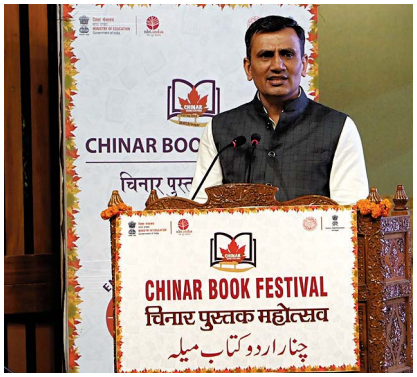
"Kiatbon ko jannat kaha gaya hai, aur kashmir ko bhi jannat kaha gaya hai. In donon jannat ka sangam hai Chinar Book festival. One needs to absorb the rich literary heritage of Kashmir through Chinar Book Festival, a "heaven of books" for readers in the "heaven on the earth"



Director, NBT-India, Sh. Yuvraj Malik, who has spent years in the valley in different positions in government, eloquently describes Kashmiriyat as a way of life steeped in civilisation, culture, traditions, and heritage.

Further adding on the literary heritage of Kashmir, Sanjeev Verma, IAS, Commissioner Secretary, J&K, says, Kashmir is the cradle of India's civilisation and an integral part of its culture. Kashmir became a significant centre for Buddhism during the Kushan Empire. In 72 AD, under the patronage of Emperor Kanishka, the 4th Buddhist Council was convened in Harwan, Srinagar, Kashmir. This council, attended by 500 monks, led to the compilation of important texts and the spread of Buddhist teachings across Asia. Comparing the scale of Chinar Book Festival, Mr Verma states that, with more than 100 literary sessions, workshops, and cultural programmes in Kashmir, this is an extension to the intellectual legacy of Kashmir and it will certainly bring about a cultural change with a greater inclination towards books and reading.

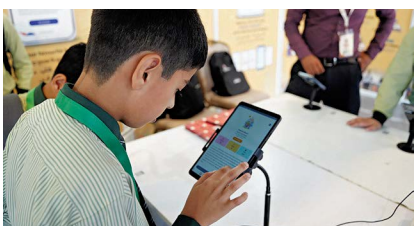


CELEBRATION OF THE LITERATURE OF KASHMIR

Through its literary stage Chinar Talks, the festival also pays homage to the influential figures who have shaped the spiritual and literary landscape of Kashmir. From the mystic poetess Lal Ded, whose verses transcended religious boundaries, to Sheikh Noor-ud-Din, who championed a culture of simplicity and compassion, and the Persian Sufi saint Bulbul Shah, the great poets and writers of Kashmir were remembered in discussions with renowned contemporary writers and poets. Interaction with Vishal Bhardwaj, Chandra Prakash Dwivedi, Aswath Bhat, Mir Sarwar. Mushtaaque Ali, Dr. Ashraf Jia, Dr. Iqbal, Afsana Nigari, Hussein Kham, Vashi Syed, and Nasir Jamir added new perspectives to the locals on the contribution of Kashmir to world literature, cinema, theatre, and intellectual traditions as well as insights on new avenues in the arts and cinema or Kashmir.



The festival also hosted over 200 publishers and booksellers from different parts of India, who exhibited a rich and rare collection of books. The festival had a dedicated zone for Urdu books, set up by NCPUL featuring 80 publishers.



This has been a wonderful platform to explore comics, general knowledge, and other genre, otherwise not taught in schools. It's been a fantastic experience for all of us."
- Syed Humza Shah, a student from Srinagar



Jammu, Kashmir & Ladakh through the ages: A Visual Narrative of Continuity and Linkages organized by ICHR, portrays the ancient texts referencing Kashmir, its early history, Indus-Saraswati civilization, introduction of Buddhism in Jammu and Kashmir, the original origin of Sanskrit Kashmir, its manuscripts, stupas, ancient temples, scholars, pundits, dynasties, and artists. The exhibition also presents information about the war in Jammu and Kashmir during British rule, including the events of 1947-48.

Prof. Raghuvendra Tanwar, Chairman of ICHR, says that the photo exhibition is particularly engaging for children and youth, as it helps them gain a deeper understanding of the Continuity of the region's history, including its ancient civilization and culture. Photo exhibition on 25 years of Kargil Vijay showcases the stories, of the brave hearts of the Kargil War with photographs, letters, and books.



Rang-e-Chinar(colours of Chinar), the Cultural Stage of the Festival provides a platform for celebrating the cultures of different parts of the nation. From Singer Rekha Bhardwaj to contemporary artist like Rahgir and bands like Shadaj, Yugm, and dance groups like Colours of Bharat in addition to sufi nights and mushaira present the true colour of Ek Bharat, Shrestha Bharat.



In the heart of the valley, Chinar Book Festival emerges as a testament to the enduring spirit of literature and the cultural vibrancy of Kashmir becomes a unifying force, enriching lives with the wisdom of words. The first edition of the 9-day Chinar Book Festival ends on 25 August 2024.

